



**Mother and baby homes (including
pre-1948 Workhouses) and
Magdalene laundries oral history
project**

Interview with LC

Anonymous (LC)

14th May 2019

Location: LC's home

Interviewed by Olivia Dee

Transcribed by Jack Crangle

Warning this transcript includes detail on sexual abuse

LC's testimony included details of her adoption after her unmarried birth mother had been placed in one of Northern Ireland's mother and baby homes. This was during the 1950s. LC was adopted but has not been able to discover details of the first three years of her life and where she was at that time. It was not a happy adoption and tragically, LC's testimony also includes discussion of abuse she suffered as a victim of a predatory, much older, male from outside the family. As a teenager, LC was driven to a Good Shepherd mother and mother and baby institution by her parish priest and her mother when she became pregnant, aged 17, during the 1960s. LC described the Good Shepherd's regime. This included LC being allocated a false name and carrying out demanding physical work. In LC's case, this included working during the days just after a traumatic process of childbirth. She described the sense of shame imposed on the girls and women in the institution: even on young teenagers who pregnant as the result of sexual abuse. LC hoped to keep her baby but felt pressurised to have the child adopted. Her account of handing her baby over (to a nun) for transfer to the adoptive parents is particularly vivid. LC remained in the home for a longer than usual amount of time after giving birth because the first adoption attempt fell through. During this period, LC explained, the nuns sent her to work as a cleaner in a neighbouring house: work for which she was not paid. LC describes two very different experiences of reuniting with family members. As an adult, she managed to locate her birth mother but the meeting

was not successful and no bond was developed. However, meetings with her adopted son have led to a strong bond between them both.

As with all the interviews, we have endeavoured to maximise LC's anonymity by redacting full details on dates, name, locations of people and institutions that feature in the testimony. Redactions are indicated by **.

OD: Okay, so we're recording now if you're happy.

LC: Okay that's fine, go ahead.

OD: So, just for the tape, my name is Olivia Dee. I have travelled to outside of Belfast to meet an anonymous interviewee who is going to tell me her story. It's the 14th of May 2019, and if you're happy then we'll get started. So we've already sort of discussed the way that we want the interview to go, and that if there's anything that you don't want to talk about you can just tell me to stop.

LC: No problem.

OD: So we may be pausing the tape if we need to. We're also joined with, by a dog, just in case there's any sound on the tape. But we're very happy about that. Okay, so can you tell me then, first of all, which homes you're connected with and why you're connected? Because as you said before we started the tape, you actually have experience as a child and a birth mother.

LC: I was born in *location redacted* to a single mother, and I was in *a Catholic mother and baby home* in, is it the *location redacted* I'm not just too sure where exactly it is. The story that I was told was that I was there until I was a year and ten months. I was then adopted into a family.

OD: And your mother was a single mother who...

LC: Single per-, she, single mother, who I later found out, her family put her out of the house and she went to live in, and I was born in the *redacted* Hospital.

OD: Okay.

LC: But in, looking up my records at the moment *identifying detail redacted*.

OD: What would your ... never mind, I'm just wondering what kind of time period this was?

LC: I was born in 195*.

OD: 195*, okay.

LC: And my adoption was finalised in *three years later*.

OD: Wow okay. So had you been fostered for a while then?

LC: Don't know.

OD: Okay.

LC: I came, seemingly I came direct. This is what I was told. I came directly from *Catholic mother and baby home* to my adopted parents.

OD: Okay. [Pause in conversation.] Interesting. So I'm assuming then that it's been a little bit difficult to find out much more information if there's, apparently, no record of you being there.

LC: It's very strange.

OD: Yeah.

LC: That's what I was told, that I was there until I was a year and ten months.

OD: And who told you?

LC: By my adopted parents.

OD: By your adopted parents.

LC: Uh-huh.

OD: Okay. And did your adopted parents have any more information on your birth mother or anything?

LC: I acquired it later in life.

OD: Okay. So if you want, we can come back to that at the end. Okay, so you have this experience and then you go to live with an adoptive family. Yep, and then what happens then?

LC: It was a good home, materially-wise. They already had three children of their own. My adopted father I was very fond of and he was very good to me, but my adopted mother was, I will say cold. I have no remembrance of a hug, a kiss, a touch, through my childhood. Materially I was well looked after, educationally I was well looked after, but emotionally it was rather bad.

OD: Yeah. That must have been hard.

LC: It was. At the age of about twelve I was sexually abused by a much older man. [Detail redacted] ... and he basically, now, in retrospect I can see he groomed me.

OD: Yeah.

LC: So it continued for a while, I can't remember how long, I've forgotten, it's too long ago.

OD: Yeah.

LC: *Redaction*

OD: No I think that sounds pretty standard after....

LC: [Testimony moved on to LC's employment after school. Details on LC's occupation redacted] ... I became pregnant, and when my mother found out I was taken immediately to a doctor, and within a very short period of time I found myself in *a Good Shepherd mother and baby home*. There wasn't a lot of consent, I was just told I was going and that was it.

OD: Had you ever been to *location redacted* before or...?

LC: No. I didn't even know where I was going. I was put in a car with the local parish priest and my mother and off I went.

OD: So that's, that's really, so you went to the doctor, and I'm assuming the doctor then spoke to your priest and the family, and they arranged...

LC: Well I think my mother went to the priest and then, you know, it was the parish priest.

OD: Yeah. Did you have a good relationship with him or...?

LC: No.

OD: Okay. That must've been really uncomfortable, because that's a really private thing and you're suddenly, kind of, driven with a man and...

LC: I was seventeen, I didn't know what I was doing or where I was going.

OD: Yeah.

LC: Cut off from my family and put in this place. And when I got there, some of my recollections are a bit faded.

OD: That's fine.

LC: When I got there, I remember going to this, like, an office, like a room, and my mother discussed with this nun all about what was happening, what was going on, da da da... And then I said goodbye to my mother, and the next thing, then, they informed me that I no longer would have my name, that I would have another name, and I was not to discuss anything about where I came from or anything about me or my name, and that was the start of my sojourn in *Good Shepherd mother and baby home*.

OD: So when they told you that you couldn't use your name, did they say why or...?

LC: Oh no, anonymity.

OD: Okay. That must've been horrible.

LC: Yeah.

OD: So did you stick to that, did you stick to the name they gave you?

LC: You had to. You'd no choice. I was *name given to LC by nuns redacted*.

OD: So it's not even close. I won't say your real name but it's not even close.

LC: No.

OD: That's, that's quite a, that's quite an adjustment to make isn't it?

LC: It is.

OD: To be completely alone and to have, so did you feel like you'd had your identity taken away?

LC: Yeah, very much so.

OD: And did you know how long you were there for?

LC: I went to there, roughly, I think after Christmas. Again, I'm waiting on the information from [the record holders].

OD: Yeah of course.

LC: Because I, it's faded, my memory, you know? I stayed there until my child was born in *month redacted*.

OD: Wow, that's a long time.

LC: And then his first adoption fell through, so I was there for longer than normal. Most girls stayed there 'til the eight weeks. I was there, I think, twelve or fourteen, I'm not sure.

OD: So when you were, sorry I'm just trying to think through my thoughts. So when you, because that is a long time and I'm trying to think of how difficult that must have been for you to, because usually the eight, six weeks or whatever, that's hard enough, but you had to go through a failed adoption. Can you tell me a little bit about how that, how that felt for you to have to...?

LC: Well I kept hoping that my parents would let me take the baby home. They came to visit and I thought, you know, once they see the baby they'll say "yes, we'll bring him home". But they didn't. So that was a last hope was dashed.

OD: And, so you were hoping there would be a connection or something?

LC: Yeah. So I had to sort of adjust my thoughts and views. And I thought well, this really is happening. When the failed adoption happened I had very mixed emotions. I was glad and sad. I was, I just didn't know what to, you know? At this time I was eighteen and I was coping with all this. And there was a lot more went on when I was in the home.

OD: It's so young.

LC: It was difficult. It was very difficult. And because the adoption had failed, I think there was an element, something to do with money, I can't really remember what it was. I mean we had no money. We never got any money, any pocket money, anything. And they were claiming benefits, and I know that. Then they put me out to work.

OD: Right.

LC: In a house next door, I had to go and clean for this couple next door. I never got paid for it. It was very difficult. It wasn't far away but I was leaving my baby to go and work in this house with these people that I didn't know.

OD: Yeah.

LC: And no money for it, no nothing. And I always felt as if they were trying to trick me. There was bits of money everywhere and I used to, I used to pile it all up into little piles. I think they thought I would steal it.

OD: Yeah.

LC: But I didn't.

OD: Oh that's horrible.

LC: Yeah. You'd go into the bedroom and there was a pile of, these piles of, you know, small coins.

OD: Yeah.

LC: So I used to pile them up into little piles.

OD: That's quite early as well, isn't it? After you've, sort of, I don't know, after you've given birth and, or you, I don't know, I suppose any work after you've given birth is quite tough, but cleaning itself is quite a strenuous job.

LC: Yep.

OD: So can you tell me about your time in that home before you gave birth, and then after, what...?

LC: It was horrendous. Horrendous. We were assigned different duties. Cleaning, cooking, laundry. We lived in a dormitory with iron beds, all very close proximity too, a lot of girls. We didn't mind. We talked after, after lights

out and things like that, you know? And we supported each other, helped each other.

OD: And did you keep that rule of not telling them anything about yourself or...?

LC: Everybody did. You told little bits about yourself but not very much.

OD: So what was it about the, I mean, obviously there's lots of elements about there that would make it unpleasant, but I was wondering if there was anything in particular that you...?

LC: I found it very demoralising. Certain times of the year, it must've been Easter or St Patrick's Day or something, this, this is a vision that never has left me in all these years. We had to put on a show for the nuns. Pregnant girls dancing and singing. And that vision's never ever left me. We were like, I can't even think of the word I want. Entertainment. Something in a circus.

OD: And why do you think they – I'm just gonna put this [the microphone] here so I don't miss you – so why do you think that was the case? What was the, like, I'm just wondering what something like that, what the purpose of something like that would be?

LC: It was a special time, a celebration, whatever.

OD: So did, were they, were they sort of making out that it was something that you would enjoy?

LC: Yes.

OD: Okay.

LC: Yes, which we didn't.

OD: So it was for your benefit, in theory. That's what they were trying to...

LC: Yeah.

OD: Okay.

LC: But there always was this element, as well, that we were bad girls, fallen girls, immoral girls. This was all, this ether was always there. And things were said slightly and, you know, I can't put it into words, but there was always this element. We had to atone for this awful crime that we had committed, you know? There was young girls there, there was girls, thirteen, twelve, you know? I knew some of their stories, some of them I didn't.

OD: To me, if you're in there at twelve or thirteen then you've not, I mean how you can be called a fallen woman, I think...

LC: Well I mean they were probably, you know, they were abused by...

OD: Yeah.

LC: ...maybe a father, an uncle, whatever. There were girls there.

OD: And that word 'fallen woman', that comes up a lot in, in a lot of what you read in the South as well, and I just feel like it's, it's a phrase that's designed to make you feel ashamed.

LC: Yeah.

OD: And I'm not sure that, I mean, that must stay with you for a very long time.

LC: Yeah.

OD: Because that word is...

LC: That carried me, that carried with me, I think, all my life.

OD: Yeah.

LC: Always. Can we pause for just one minute please?

OD: Yeah of course.

[Recording paused]

[Recording resumes]

OD: We're restarting the tape there. So we were talking about your, that word atonement, and all the connotations of it. And then, also, the kind of fact that you were made to sort of sing and dance, and for your own kind of enjoyment, however.

LC: It wasn't our enjoyment, it was theirs. There was always this element, you know, as I said, fallen woman, and bad girls. And you had to, you know, this awful thing that you had done. And you, it made you feel nearly unworthy, like second-class. And, funny, that has stayed with me for a long, long time. Not good enough. Not good enough. And in my own history, because I was – to me, I wasn't really – I was rejected as a small baby, that carried on and carried on, and then again, going into *a Good Shepherd mother and baby home*, again there was the rejection from my adopted parents because I had the audacity to produce this child and, you know? There was no looking into why it happened or how it happened or.

OD: And did you ever tell them about what had happened when you were twelve, thirteen?

LC: No, no. They never knew. Never knew. But I can look back now at, you know, why...

OD: Yeah.

LC: ...this behaviour, you know?

OD: Well you were twelve.

LC: Yeah.

OD: I mean, that was, I mean there's no, there's no...

LC: But then following on.

OD: Yeah.

LC: The promiscuity and, you know, yes, I can see why.

OD: Yeah. And did you ever, kind of, talk to your family about the fact that you had come from a very similar situation and there-, you know, therefore adoption was a wonderful thing that, you know, you had experienced, and that maybe they would want to...

LC: No.

OD: Okay.

LC: No, all, growing up, I never understood why they adopted me. They had three children of their own, and no matter where we went people would say, you know, "what a pretty child" or, you know, "she's beautiful hair" or "she's gorgeous". And my adopted mother would always turn round and say "oh yes, but she's adopted".

OD: Oh okay.

LC: All the time. Again, never quite fitting in, never quite being accepted.

OD: That must've been hard.

LC: But it's only in retrospect now I can see all those things, you know?

OD: And that's why I think it was good that you were able to get some, kind of, talking help through that, so that you can, you can, because the chronology of

that, it's very self-explanatory, but if you've lived it, it doesn't look that easy to understand does it?

LC: No, no it doesn't.

OD: So I'm really glad someone's able to kind of...

LC: Oh yeah.

OD: Make you realise that. When you say that you were sort of made to feel like less than, or ashamed or anything, what kind of ways did the nuns make you feel that way?

LC: It was very subtle.

OD: Yeah, I can imagine.

LC: You know, we were made to scrub floors, and we had to do these things, and everything was very regimented and we weren't allowed to do this and we weren't allowed to do that, and were to keep quiet at certain times, and all those elements. As I say, they were very subtle. They took us out for walks, that's another image I still have. You know the way you would see a crocodile of small children?

OD: Yeah.

LC: That's the way we were taken out for a walk.

OD: So you were sort of infantilised?

LC: It was the fresh air, you know?

OD: But you were all kind of visibly pregnant?

LC: Pregnant, yes all these pregnant girls all...

OD: We're just pausing it.

[Recording paused.]

[Recording resumes.]

OD: We're just restarting. So you were going for walks?

LC: Yes. Which, as I say, they took us out for walks crocodile-style like you do with small children. And it was a bit demeaning. After I was there a while I think they kind of trusted me a little bit, 'cause I was allowed to go to the hospital and all on my own, which was, you know, a bit of a breakthrough. And I used to go and sit in a little café and drink a cup of coffee before I come back.

OD: Yeah.

LC: It was my only thrill.

OD: So it was some time when you were able to kind of, I don't know, be your...

LC: Pretend, pretend to be myself, yeah.

OD: And how were you treated at *hospital redacted*?

LC: Terrible.

OD: Yeah.

LC: Again, this attitude. Not from my own staff, now, but from some of the staff. You know, single girl, young girl, pregnant. Some people were sympathetic, some people weren't. But at the time of my son's birth it was horrendous. I had a midwife who was very unsympathetic. I was brought into the delivery room and I was left alone. And...

[sound of rearrangement of the audio equipment]

LC: It was difficult. I was on my own every day. I really, I knew the mechanics but I didn't really know what was going to happen, and it was scary, it was really scary. And there was no-one to support me, no-one to talk to. And, finally, I actually ripped.

OD: Oh!

LC: There was a whole flap on, then the, they couldn't finish the delivery, but the damage had been done. By that time, I suppose, I was nearly beside myself. And the baby was born, I was sutured up very dismissively, and went back into the ward again afterwards, and again, alone. No visitors, no nobody, in a public ward with everybody all gawping at me and looking at me.

OD: Yeah.

LC: Which was difficult. So we went quite quickly after the birth, we went quite quickly home. Well, to the home; not home.

OD: Who came and, did someone come and pick you up?

LC: I don't remember.

OD: Yeah.

LC: That's the one thing I don't remember, I really don't. I can't remember whether they brought me home, who brought me home or what.

OD: You couldn't have walked, could you?

LC: No no, I didn't walk, no. With a baby?

OD: Maybe like a taxi? Yeah. But also just yourself. How, you must've been in so much pain.

LC: I don't remember.

OD: Okay.

LC: And at the back it was okay. Oh, previous to the baby being born, they put me in a private room.

OD: Oh okay.

LC: Because they took me out of the dormitory, put me in a private room, and I had problems with blood pressure.

OD: So did you have preeclampsia or were they just worried?

LC: No I didn't. They were just worried about the blood pressure. So I went to, I was allowed into the single room. And when I came back I still had the single room and the baby went to the nursery. Which is, I think, something that they've denied, that there was a nursery, but there was a nursery.

OD: Oh yeah, I think, yeah, that's interesting.

LC: Yeah.

OD: That's something we'll have to look up.

LC: There was a nursery.

OD: Would you have want-, so you couldn't have him with you or...?

LC: No.

OD: Okay.

LC: Oh no, you had things to do. We were very back into the routine of...

OD: And how many days in between birth and, and getting back into that routine?

LC: I can't even remember, but it wasn't long. I remember one day, I do remember one day I was so tired, I was exhausted, and I went to the room and I lay down and I slept, and I didn't hear or wake up in time to feed the baby. And, oh dear, did I feel so bad, and I was made to feel very bad. How could I do this? Oh, this was dreadful. "We knocked the door, you didn't get up", da da da da da [indicating a repetitive lecturing tone]. It made me feel as if I was the worst person in the world.

OD: Wow.

LC: And, you know, when we were feeding the babies, we were down there feeding the babies with no support, no help, no anybody to show you what to do.

OD: Yeah. That must've been terrifying.

LC: You had this baby and, you know, what did you do with it?

OD: Yeah. I think it's even scary now when people have it, isn't it? And, you know, that it's completely different, you know, you get all this support and people, and mothers are still overwhelmed, and you're expected to do it at the age of eighteen with no, no help.

LC: And young; there was other girls younger than me.

OD: Yeah.

LC: I know, and we used to, you know, we didn't know the difference, like I remember, sort of, girls and maybe shaking their babies and things like that and, not shaking in anger.

OD: Yeah I know what you mean, like trying to...

LC: You know, maybe get wind up or something.

OD: Yeah.

LC: But we did - we didn't know.

OD: Yeah.

LC: So not long after that they moved me back into the dormitory. I have a feeling – but I could be wrong – that they were being paid extra for me to be in a single room.

OD: That your parents were paying?

LC: Mm-hmm.

OD: Yeah.

LC: I cannot prove it, but there's something in my head tells me that.

OD: And did you ever ask them?

LC: No.

OD: Did you never speak about it?

LC: No.

OD: It's one of the things that seems to come out of this, as being so damaging, is that you come right out of what is probably one of the most traumatic things you'll ever experience and you can't talk with the people around you, and the other women. I'm assuming you couldn't talk to the other women about the birth or what you'd gone through?

LC: Oh we did talk, yes we did. We did, oh we did, yeah. We talked and we joked and we were very supportive of one another that was one thing.

OD: That's nice.

LC: You know, when we were feeding the babies we would've talked and, you know, and complained about this, that and the other, or, you know? And "how did you feel about this?" And "how did you deal with that?" And "I've got so-and-so, have you got...?" You know?

OD: And did that give you a sense of, maybe what was going to happen during birth? If you were able, were you able to kind of talk a little bit so that you could at least try and get some knowledge together about what birth was and how to look after a baby and...?

LC: A little bit. A little bit. It was more after the birth, I think, we bonded a bit better than before. Because I think we were all in the same boat.

OD: Yeah I can imagine. I'm just concerned by you saying you're getting back into that routine of cleaning when you've had stitches and you, you know, I mean that's a pretty major thing to have happened. And I'm worried that you, you know, were you – oops – were you bleeding or was there any kind of problems after that, with going straight back into a routine?

LC: It was hard.

OD: Yeah.

LC: Very, very difficult. And I mean there was even things like you had to go to chapel. No matter what you felt like you had to go to chapel. And I had a merciful row with them over it.

OD: Yeah.

LC: I don't really do authority very well, and I think it stems, maybe from, again from my childhood and maybe from...

OD: Yeah.

LC: From there. I had a massive row with the priest, and the nuns, because I didn't want to go to chapel. Why should I?

OD: Yeah.

LC: You know? I was tired or I was not well or I, I don't just remember what it was, but it was horrendous.

OD: Well you'd just given birth in a traumatic way, I mean...

LC: I know, it's horrendous.

OD: Yeah. I think my mum said she didn't get out of bed for about three weeks afterwards, she just, everyone had to do things for her.

LC: Yeah.

OD: I just, yeah, I can't even imagine having to get up...

LC: There was no, no, there was no, no, what would you say? No sympathy.

OD: Yeah.

LC: No support, no, support yeah.

OD: So when you argued with the priests, what, what were the arguments? You know?

LC: I just gave off because we had to go to church, I think.

OD: Yeah. I'm just wondering what, what, why he felt that you so badly needed to go to church one week out of all of them.

LC: Well, no, we had to go to church on a regular basis.

OD: I know but if, if you're just trying to, you know, say "look, I'm really tired, I'm ill..."

LC: No, you had to go.

OD: Okay. And was that for you own, kind of, soul?

LC: I haven't a clue what the idea was. I'll be honest, I walked away from religion at that stage. I have never been, well except for a wedding, I am not interested in organised religion at all.

OD: Was it hard having people around you who'd never given birth, and would never give birth, and had never experienced that, being the ones in authority and telling you "no, get up, clean, go to chapel"? That must've been hard.

LC: It was. As I was saying, there was no sympathy at all. There was no, you know, "oh go and lie down for half an hour", or "you're looking tired". No, no.

OD: Yeah.

LC: I mean after I moved into the, back into the dormitory again, I had a massive boil under my arm and, it's just I was run down, and nobody bothered. Nobody was interested. So one afternoon I went down, managed to get a little – you had a little bit of free time – I went and I sat on the bed and I got a flannel, and I kept running it under the hot tap and putting it under my arm, doing it repeatedly, repeatedly, to try and draw this massive boil. And I did in the end. But again there was no, there really was no care.

OD: What about aftercare for your...?

LC: There was no aftercare.

OD: ...pregnancy.

LC: There was no aftercare.

OD: Like stitch removal and things like that.

LC: I can't even remember, I think I went to the hospital to get the stitches out.

OD: Okay.

LC: But you were just more or less told "take a shower", "take a bath", whatever. That was it. And again, even then, you know, at that stage you had no privacy. You know, they were there all the time. What were they watching? I don't know, what were they looking at?

OD: I feel really, it's really hard to see how, with the chain of events that happened to you, how you weren't given more help in what was clearly something that was incredibly difficult and was, stemmed from abuse and stemmed from childhood trauma and things like that.

LC: Well I never would have spoke about the abuse at that stage.

OD: I know, but it's still, it's still hard to know that that's something that you...

LC: No, you would-, you're just left to. I mean, basically, you went there, you had your baby, they arranged the adoption, you had no say in the matter. That was it. So, then, when you're finished and the baby went to wherever it was going, you went home.

OD: Yeah.

LC: And I went home, it was never spoken of again, ever.

OD: So, I'm well aware this might be a difficult thing to talk about, but as much as I can, can I ask you a little bit about that adoption? So what, you obviously have a failed adoption that falls through, and you think that's something to do with money but you're not certain.

LC: Don't know what happened there.

OD: Yeah, but something happened and the baby stayed.

LC: Yes.

OD: And you sort of discussed...

LC: Then a few weeks later...

OD: ...the way you felt about that, which was a real mix of emotions.

LC: Yeah.

OD: But must've been an absolute...

LC: Yeah, it very, was. It was like a roller coaster. One minute you were sort of pleased it had fallen through, the next minute you were sad.

OD: Yeah. And how much notice were you given before babies were sort of taken to adopted homes? Did they say, you know, “we found someone, they’re gonna go in a week”? Or was it the same day or...?

LC: No, there was a bit of time.

OD: Okay.

LC: I can’t remember how much, but it wasn’t much. A few days maybe, I think it was a few days. So, sort of gave you time to realise what was happening, and I sat down and I wrote a letter. And I put it in, I had a bag of things, clothes, little toys and I put it in with them and I just hoped and prayed that the nuns wouldn’t take it. And that was it, I, it was the hardest day of my life. I will never forget. You had to hand over your baby and...

OD: They made you hand it?

LC: Yes. Not to the adoptive parents, to the nun. And watch her walk away down this long corridor. And I can still see that. It was a very difficult day. And then, that same day, I went to my home, and I had to walk out through that door and go home. And it was never spoken of again, as if it never happened. So again, all those things got buried right down again. And it is damaging, you know, I know that now.

OD: Of course.

LC: You can only suppress emotions for so long, so.

OD: How were you treated when you went home? I know you said they didn't acknowledge it, but was there any, any care for you in any way?

LC: Not really, no [Pauses]. I sort of can't explain it. If I went out, you know, it was "are you going to do this again?" Type of thing, or, you know?

OD: Oh.

LC: There was this cons-, no not constant, but it was this, it was said.

OD: So, at this point, you were eighteen?

LC: Eighteen.

OD: And when did you manage to, kind of, leave home?

LC: Not long afterwards, I managed to get a place, well I think my parents actually arranged it, or sorted it out. I managed to get a place in *occupational detail redacted*.

OD: Oh great, so you could go back and do...

LC: I went back into *occupational detail redacted*, but I'd lost all my, the bit I'd done before. And off I went. But the *line manager*, at the time it was *line manager*, she knew my circumstances, and let's put it this way, she didn't let me forget it.

OD: Really?

LC: There was always a wee edge.

OD: I bet there were loads of women there though who had a similar experience in some ways, and couldn't talk about it.

LC: Well...

OD: Or maybe not, I don't know.

LC: You don't know. You don't know. Because you, again, that was all buried. And when I went to *workplace location redacted* I changed my name. I'm not going to say it.

OD: No, you don't have to.

LC: I changed, I've had so many names. I had my birth name, my adopted name, and then my third name.

OD: Okay. And why not go back to your original name, what...?

LC: Because I wanted to put the past behind me.

OD: Okay. And I'm assuming you had no feelings towards the one they gave you when you were in *Good Shepherd mother and baby home*?

LC: No, no.

OD: So you wanted to get rid of that as well.

LC: Wanted to get rid. Oh, I forgot about that one.

OD: Yeah.

LC: That was four names. And just get, get a hanky.

OD: I've got some here.

LC: No I'm fine, I'm fine. No, it was like a new start, a new beginning.

OD: Yeah.

LC: I used my other name and I've used it all my life since. So the person that I was before is no longer.

OD: Yeah. It's really hard, because I have really mixed feelings about that. You, because I'm sad that you had to, but I'm really happy that you managed to create something that you've managed to use all the way through. So, you've sort of managed to separate, and I can see that that's...

LC: It's like I had to. And I didn't really realise that I was doing it, but I probably was doing it for my own sanity.

OD: Doing something for yourself as well.

LC: Yeah.

OD: Yeah.

LC: And I had, I had to, because I had to put all that pain and heartbreak and, it was the most demoralising horrible part of my life.

OD: And did you do the same thing with, again I won't ask you what they are, but did you do the same thing with, sort of, family surnames as well? Did you change your last name?

LC: No. No, I didn't change my last name until I was married.

OD: Okay. So when you were in *workplace redacted* and you're having this, kind of, was it passive-aggressive...

LC: Reincarnation.

OD: Yeah. But was it, was it passive-aggressive from the *line manager*, or was it kind of...?

LC: Just little niggles.

OD: Yeah, I can imagine.

LC: Little snide remarks now and again.

OD: So did you stick that out? Did you stay there and finish?

LC: I stayed there and then went on, *workplace redacted* opened then, I went to *workplace redacted* and finished my training. And in the meantime I met my husband and I married him.

OD: So was that sort of the first time then that you'd felt, you'd kind of created your new self?

LC: Person, aye.

OD: And you've found the job that you want and you've found someone that you, kind of, married. And is that the first time that you felt that you had that control that was taken from you, back, partially? Or did you still feel like everything that had happened to you was still there?

LC: Everything that happened was still there. Because it did affect my marriage, I know it did.

OD: And could you tell your husband about that?

LC: Yes, he knew.

OD: Okay. That must've taken a lot of courage.

LC: I told him before we got married.

OD: Not because I think it was anything that you've done wrong, just because I think so many people had told you...

LC: I think he, I think he needed to know. Well I felt he needed to know if we were going to marry. And then we went on and we had [three] children. But he, you know, he made it quite clear that if he'd have met me with the child he would have found it very difficult to rear that child. So, again, that was kind of another slap in the teeth.

OD: Yeah.

LC: I think we could write a book on this.

OD: You could. Any one of...

LC: And nobody would believe it.

OD: But that's why I'm so glad that you're talking, because I think it's really important that people do listen and do believe it.

LC: It's cathartic.

OD: And I think, I don't know, I think you've, you've done a lot for yourself to kind of take that control back, and I, it's hard to hear that, you know, there were still parameters in your new life where you couldn't talk about cert-, well you couldn't perhaps talk about the son or the child.

LC: You could never tell the truth.

OD: Yeah.

LC: And then, because of the, the situation in our little country, you couldn't discuss an awful lot of things.

OD: Yeah.

LC: I came from, well, my birth mother jumped the fence quite a few times religious-wise, so I don't really know what she was at the end.

OD: Yeah.

LC: But I was adopted into a Catholic family. I married a Protestant and I also married a guy who was *occupation redacted*. So again, secrecy, I feel as if I've lived my life telling lies. You know, people say – not now – people say to me “how many children do you have?” And I say, I'd have to say two. Whereas I was, mentally, going three. And that went on for so long, you know.

OD: And when people ask you now do you say three?

LC: Yes.

OD: Good. That's really powerful I think.

LC: Yeah.

OD: So when you, the first, so you married a Protestant man first? Was that the first time you were married, and then [you married the man who was] *occupation redacted* afterwards, or was it the same [man]?

LC: No same, same person.

OD: Oh okay.

LC: Same person.

OD: Was he from *location redacted* or...?

LC: No, he was from here.

OD: Oh okay. Wow.

LC: And we bought this house together.

OD: Which we can't see because we're on tape.

LC: Yeah.

OD: But it is a very beautiful house.

LC: Thank you very much.

OD: So we've got a really good sense of your story then, a really interesting sort of timeline. We usually do sometimes ask about the process of trying to find children or things like that. But we ask, I'll ask you before I talk about it whether that's something you are...

LC: That's fine.

OD: Are you interested in having that, kind of, as part of the story.

LC: I already found my son.

OD: Good, okay.

LC: My son found me actually.

OD: So I'm assuming, so you gave birth in the 1960s?

LC: *date redacted*.

OD: So I'm thinking about all the laws that kind of change around that time period, a little bit later, and obviously having to wait until they're eighteen, or, you know, he has to find you. Yeah, all of those things would've been relevant in your case.

LC: I never tried. Well I did try, I tried a little bit to find him. But I was afraid.

OD: Yeah.

LC: Afraid of wrecking his life, afraid of rejection, afraid that he didn't know he was adopted. So many fears. So, I tentatively tried to find out. I met a girl who had been in *the same Good Shepherd mother and baby home* and was able to tell me that he was in *location redacted*. She had seen him. And, no it wasn't *location redacted*, I tell a lie, it was *another location*. So, and I'd been told a little bit of information about what his father had worked at. So I started to look up all these guys who worked in that profession in the phonebook.

OD: Oh it's like pre, pre-internet and everything. It must've been so much work.

LC: And then I would back off.

OD: Yeah.

LC: And then I would look another wee while, think about it another wee while. After the birth of my first, well my second son, I had very bad post-natal depression. And I got terribly mixed up, I thought it was, can I say their names?

OD: You can, we'll take them off the transcript, so you can say whatever you want.

LC: I started to get very mixed up, and I thought *second son* was *first son/the adopted son*.

OD: So *name redacted* was your first son?

LC: Yes. I got terribly mixed up and ended up having...

OD: Oh, poor thing.

LC: ... I attended what they called *detail redacted* then. And attended there for quite a while, as an outpatient not as an inpatient. But again it was, it was all interconnected. Okay, it was post-natal depression, but it also was a lot to do with *adopted son* and, you know.

OD: Were you better supported through your second birth? Was there more to help you with that?

LC: Physically, in the hospital?

OD: So [either the] pain relief or having someone with you?

LC: Oh yes, yes, yes.

OD: Or being told, you know, what's happening, or being, consenting?

LC: Yes, it was much better.

OD: Yeah.

LC: But it was a bit of a difficult birth, and by the time I had my third son I was much better supported.

OD: Good. I can't, I can't, I can't kind of say that it seems surprising. I mean, to me, trying to go into a second birth with no support, having not been able to really talk about what happened during your first one. I mean I think women just deserved so much more than that.

LC: Yeah.

OD: For the second and third births. It doesn't matter, you know, all the things about shame or whatever. It doesn't mat-, all of that aside, physically you deserve so much more than that.

LC: Yeah.

OD: And I am glad that by the third one you were able to get.

LC: Oh yeah, much easier birth.

OD: Yeah.

LC: And, I mean my consultant and all knew...

OD: Good.

LC: ...at the time, that I was having *third child's name redacted*, they knew that I already had a previous child. Because you have to tell anyway. You know, when you go in.

OD: Did they know the circumstances or...?

LC: No.

OD: Okay.

LC: They just knew that I'd had another child that was, just basically that I have a child that's eighteen and that was adopted, and that was it.

OD: So, I'm assuming then, once you kind of come back from the post-natal depression, then you, kind of, are helped back to, kind of feeling more able to take care of [your second son]. Is that when you start thinking about [your first son] again?

LC: Yeah.

OD: And getting in contact.

LC: Yeah.

OD: How did your husband feel about that?

LC: He didn't really encourage it.

OD: Yeah.

LC: As I, he said he couldn't cope with it, he didn't think he could cope with it.

OD: Did you have anyone supporting you at that time?

LC: No. So it was dropped again.

OD: Okay.

LC: Then when I had *name redacted*, that's my youngest boy, again it all came to a fore. But it wasn't just my, it wasn't just my own son, it was my own, I needed to find my roots. Who am I? Who really am I?

OD: Yeah.

LC: Where did I come from?

OD: Yeah.

LC: And that was, it was like something eating you up inside, and it really, really came to the fore. I had to find out [Pauses]. Because, again, when I was growing up, I'm small in stature, quite light hair, although it's white now. I had quite blue eyes, pale skin. My brothers and sisters had brown eyes, dark hair.

OD: Yeah.

LC: Taller in stature. And it always was obvious.

OD: Yeah.

LC: There was no familial, you know, resemblance.

OD: Well there's no connection between you and, you know, there was no resemblance.

LC: No physical. No, no physical resemblance at all.

OD: And your mother, you said that your mother always highlighted that you were...

LC: Always pointing it out, yes.

OD: Yeah.

LC: So there was a quest, then, a big quest to go and find out who I was. And that really, it was very strong. That's why I concentrated more on that than finding *name of first son*.

OD: I can see that that would be really important.

LC: Yeah.

OD: So again you're dealing with much fewer resources than we have now. So how do you begin to try and do that? I'm in awe of it as a historian.

LC: One more pause.

OD: Yes of course.

[Interview paused.]

[Interview resumes.]

LC: I think it's....

OD: Right, just restarting.

LC: So I was saying that...

OD: Trying to find your...

LC: That focus was on trying to find, you know, where I came from and who my birth mother was and my family. And I did focus on that. And it was so funny, my birth name is a very unusual name.

OD: Okay.

LC: So I looked up the phonebook, the days that there were phonebooks. And the first person with my name, I rung it.

OD: Okay.

LC: And I made up a story that I was looking for a friend of my mother's. And I found my birth mother's brother and niece.

OD: Wow!

LC: And after a bit of a conversation with the niece I just came out with it.

OD: Wow!

LC: That I, who I was looking for. And she said "I need to talk to my daddy, can we ring you back?" And I said "no problem", gave them the number, and they rang me back later and confirmed to us who I was looking for.

OD: Wow!

LC: And that time she was living in *location redacted*.

OD: Oh okay.

LC: She had married and had two more children. She was living in *location redacted*, and so that seemed to be kind of a, kind of a dead end. I didn't know what to do, whether to go to *location redacted*, etc. But a little bit of time elapsed, I contacted – she's my cousin – I contacted and had a chat with her several times, and then she informed me that she was moving back to Northern Ireland.

OD: Wow.

LC: So my cousin arranged for a meeting in her house, so I went down to see her. And unfortunately it was a bit of a disaster.

OD: Oh.

LC: There was nothing there. I think, now when I look back on things, life had treated her so badly that she was just sucked dry, there was nothing. She talked about her girls, and she did give me cards, a few cards and things, but it's like talking to, I don't know, I can't even explain it. There was nothing. Just nothing.

OD: What were your ages at this point?

LC: What was my age?

OD: Yeah, because I'm trying to think what...

LC: I'm trying to think. My children were small *discusses children's ages in relation to possible date*.

OD: So about 198*?

LC: Round about that, yeah.

OD: So you would've been, sort of late twenties or...

LC: Yes.

OD: Late twenties. I just, the reason I ask is that I'm trying to put myself in the position of, you leave someone when they're a baby and then you meet them again when they're almost thirty. It's hard to know [what] you expect and how, and how you think a meeting like that might go.

LC: I think it was all glamourised. You see things on the television.

OD: Oh yeah.

LC: Open arms and all this.

OD: Yeah.

LC: No, no, it didn't happen, no. It was, she was so blank. She was so blank. It was, I couldn't even explain it. There was just nothing there. There was no response that these were her grandchildren. And I met her twice and - because I walked away at that stage. I walked away from her and I walked away from my cousin, I walked away from them all. I really didn't want to know because I felt so rejected, again [Pauses]. I got a lot of information about her from my cousin and from, it would have been her brother.

OD: Yeah.

LC: Sent me a lot of information about her and her family and the circumstances that she was faced with.

OD: And were they similar to yours or...?

LC: Worse. Her mother died. Quite a big family, my grandfather was head gatekeeper in a big estate. He remarried and there was a lot of friction with the new wife and the children, and eventually then she became pregnant and he threw her out. That's how she ended up in *a Catholic mother and baby home* But he, and it's still a mystery about what went on there. I don't know what happened.

OD: Yeah.

LC: According to the girl from [the record holders for this home] I could not have been there for a year and ten months. So where was I? But anyway.

OD: That is a really long time isn't it? To not appear in any records. I'm just wondering if you were in a foster care situation or something.

LC: No, I was with mummy. Because my adopted mother told me I stood and cried at the window for my wee mummy. So I was with her, wherever I was.

OD: Interesting. And she, she didn't know?

LC: She didn't, I, we didn't.

OD: Didn't talk.

LC: We didn't talk.

OD: That's understandable.

LC: As I was saying, there was nothing. There was no...

OD: And when you decided to kind of walk away, was that, did she accept that? That was just...

LC: That was the end of it, yeah.

OD: So how did that make you feel about trying to find your child?

LC: My own child?

OD: Yeah.

LC: It knocked me back again.

OD: I'm not surprised.

LC: Because I thought no, I can't go through all that again. So I just got on with life and rearing my children and working, and my husband was away quite a lot so I was on my own quite a lot.

OD: Was he still *occupational detail redacted* at this point?

LC: Mm-hmm.

OD: Yeah.

LC: And then, *date redacted* – he took his own life. And I found him in the hay-barn up there. So...

OD: Do you want me to stop?

LC: No, I'm okay. So I had to deal with that, and sixteen weeks later his sister died very suddenly. And her and I were quite good chums. So, again, I was left on my own. His parents couldn't deal with it, couldn't deal with me, couldn't deal with the children, and I was left on my own to deal with everything. And then thoughts of *name of first son* came rearing up again. I remember sitting here one night, and my youngest boy was here with his girlfriend, and I'd had a few drinks and I started to cry. And it was all about his brother.

OD: So did you begin, then, to talk, maybe, about it?

LC: A little bit, yeah.

OD: Okay.

LC: But then it lay down again. So it was a difficult, very difficult time. I went into counselling with *name of organisation redacted*. I addressed some of the issues, not all of them.

OD: I feel like trying to tackle all of it at once would, would make anyone feel, kind of, overwhelmed and...

LC: It was like letting the genie out of the bottle.

OD: Yeah, I feel like just to take care of yourself you needed to kind of isolate different things and focus, I can really understand that.

LC: Yeah.

OD: So how do you finally manage to kind of get to the point where you, oh he looked for you, you said.

LC: Yes, he found me. Out of the blue, I got this letter. And, you know the way they sort of write this letter, it was very kind of vague, that this man is looking for his mother, and could it be you? And if it is, can you contact?

OD: Yeah. And was that a letter from *name of organisation redacted* or was that...?

LC: It wasn't *name of organisation redacted*. I still, I have the letter. It was from social services.

OD: Right okay.

LC: It must be the depart-, I can't remember now. So then this girl come, this lady came down to see me, and we talked it all through, and "would I like to meet him?" And all this. And I said yes, I would. And he came up to meet me.

OD: Wow. And what's going through your heart at that point? Because obviously you've been in his position. You know what it's like to go and meet a family.

LC: I was so excited.

OD: Then, oh that's, and I suppose you, yeah.

LC: A little bit of fear.

OD: Yeah.

LC: Would he like me? Would he not like me?

OD: But wanting to, I guess, talk and not, sort of the way...

LC: Will he forgive me for what I done? Is there any animosity? But excitement and joy, to a certain degree. This, finally, made me, I'm going to meet him. After forty odd years I was going to meet him. And it was, it was lovely.

OD: Yeah.

LC: Yeah it was lovely. It all worked out well.

OD: Yeah.

LC: He's a lovely man.

OD: But I think, as well, you should take a huge part of that on yourself. That you, you are also responsible for that going well, and you, you were able to bring warmth and love and excitement, and some of the things that, perhaps, you hadn't got when you had done the same thing. And he, that probably meant so much to him to have that, I suppose.

LC: Yeah.

OD: To have someone who wanted to meet him and was excited to meet him and...

LC: I was.

OD: Yeah.

LC: And it's funny, if you look round you'll see some teddy bears.

OD: Oh yeah.

LC: Well one, well one of them was called *name of adopted son*. So I managed to get one the same. So gave him *to adopted son* a teddy bear before he left, and it was, strangest, strangest feeling I've ever had in my life. We connected.

OD: Yeah.

LC: We immediately connected. It was like [unclear].

OD: And did, did he come, kind of, very willing to have that relationship and...?

LC: Yes.

OD: Okay.

LC: Yes.

OD: That's great.

LC: I think he was, he'd been told a few things that weren't true.

OD: Yeah.

LC: It seems to be par for the course. I was told quite a few things that weren't true either. But anyway, I was told my mother was a prostitute. My birth mother ... isn't that nice? I don't think she was.

OD: Well even if, even, even if, I mean, I mean who...?

LC: Well she wouldn't have been in *a Catholic mother and baby home*, probably, if she was a, a working girl.

OD: Exactly. But also there's so many circumstances around different...

LC: Yeah.

OD: And I just feel like we, it's not...

LC: It's a different world we're living in.

OD: Yeah. We don't know what she went through.

LC: But I mean he was told I came from a different area to where I did. He was told all sorts of different things.

OD: Yeah.

LC: And I suppose he was worried and scared too about what he was gonna meet. Am I imagining things, what if I am? I think he was told, I think he was told I was a heavy drinker.

OD: Okay. Maybe it's something to do with trying to establish new families and it, it's easier if you're, I'm just wondering if, if people feel like it's easier to kind of say "oh it was a very difficult situation" and, you know "you're much better off here" or, you know, it's, it's a way of trying to...

LC: I think the holy women in that certain establishment told lies.

OD: Okay.

LC: Yeah.

OD: And do you think that was because it was easier to ease someone into a family if, yeah...?

LC: You're saving this child.

OD: Yeah.

LC: From an alcoholic or whatever or...

OD: Instead of a seventeen year old...

LC: Yeah.

OD: ...who wants you. I suppose that's the hard thing.

LC: Who broke her heart.

OD: Yeah. Because you can't, yeah.

LC: But when I did meet *adopted son* it was the funniest thing, I remember thinking to myself I could die now.

OD: Oh gosh!

LC: No, I'm quite happy to die now.

OD: Yeah.

LC: You know? I know it sounds a really strange thing to say.

OD: In a way, in a way it makes me kind of go "oh", but then I do understand what, you've had this over your life for, for the entirety of your life has been something that everyone around you...

LC: It was such a relief.

OD: Yeah.

LC: And I talk away about him now, I don't hold back.

OD: You shouldn't.

LC: People talk about family and I say “oh, my son’s coming up to see me”, and, you know, coming up and he’s bringing the girls up, and all this and...

OD: So you have grandchildren?

LC: Yes.

OD: And they come here?

LC: I have met them. The first time I met them he didn’t tell them who I was, and he said he regrets that very much.

OD: And...

LC: But they know now who I am. They don’t call me granny or nanny or anything like that, because I’m not. I mean I didn’t see them grow up. They don’t really call me anything.

OD: Yeah.

LC: And *adopted son* calls me *interviewee’s name redacted*

OD: We’ll take it out [reference to her name].

LC: But he rings me on Mother’s Day, which is very special. It really is very special.

OD: Yeah.

LC: You know? The first time he done it I just, I couldn't believe it. Because, at the end of the day, I'm his mother but I'm not his mum. He has his mum.

OD: He does, but you...

LC: I gave birth to him but I didn't bring him up.

OD: But there's something there.

LC: Oh there's a big connection.

OD: There's a connection.

LC: There's a big...

OD: And he was looking for it.

LC: Yeah.

OD: And I think that's important.

LC: I honestly, I think because he was a boy I didn't really think he would come looking.

OD: Yeah.

LC: I suppose that's, that's a silly assumption really. But...

OD: Well I don't know, I can understand it. We have, we have so many ideas about what men and women will do, and we associate so much of these stories with the women and everything, and I think it's really special that he came. I think it, it says quite a lot about what he was feeling and also...

LC: He obviously felt there was something missing in his life.

OD: Yeah.

LC: And I think he wanted, again, like I did, he wanted to see where he came from.

OD: Yeah definitely.

LC: And it sounds awfully big headed, but he's seeing what I am like now. He's seeing a different idea to what he maybe thought, because of what he had been told.

OD: Yeah. And I think that's a really crucial part of your story is that you had a chance to correct some of the things that people told you.

LC: Misconceptions.

OD: Yeah, because that's, that's, that's coloured a whole part of his life and you were able to break that, and he was able to see that. That's, I think your story is so special for that reason, and that, I'm so happy that it had that, had that conclusion.

LC: Good ending.

OD: Yeah, and that you, not only him, but there's a family there as well, and you...

LC: I mean, he's met up with his brothers, they've gone out and socialised, they've brought up the wives and went into *location redacted*.

OD: Good.

LC: My youngest boy has gone to see him. He lives quite a distance away, and my youngest boy and his wife have gone down to visit. Now they didn't stay with them, but they stayed in a hotel and he took them out round to his area and showed them.

OD: That's great.

LC: So I don't know that he introduced them, or did he introduce them? I don't know.

OD: Right.

LC: That's something you have to tread carefully with.

OD: Yeah, and I suppose once you've done it, as well, maybe the titles are slightly less important.

LC: I haven't been to where he lives.

OD: Okay.

LC: But someday I will, I hope. As I say, it's quite a distance, and for us to go now, my partner – as I told you – is quite elderly and I don't want him to drive that distance.

OD: Yeah.

LC: He couldn't anyway, and I don't think I could. But my youngest boy has said someday he'll take me down. So maybe in the summer we might plan it, try and go down. I'd like to see where he lives.

OD: Yeah.

LC: Again, I don't want to encroach on his life. I would love to meet his adoptive parents. Just to meet them and say thank you.

OD: Yeah.

LC: And that's it. Not to cause any rows or ructions or, you know?

OD: Yeah I don't, I don't think it would have to. I think...

LC: No.

OD: ...You're a very, you know, that relationship is one that lots of people will never have. But you – you know, the adoptive parents and birth mother relationship – but you've come into this with so much kind of love and affection for him and everything, I think they would only see that.

LC: I never stopped loving him from the day I had him.

OD: Yeah I think that's really obvious.

LC: Okay, I didn't think about him every day, but I did think about him. I think that was one of the reasons why I didn't push the issue of looking for him. I'd love to let him get on with it, you know? But I never dreamt the day he would come looking me. I never dreamt it, and I'll be honest, I mean I was in hysterics when I read the letter, but at the same time I was so euphoric, I was so happy [Pauses]. I was able to put a full stop, you know? Close the book on that chapter.

OD: I think that's a really lovely kind of way to, I don't know, I think you've told the story beautifully. Really beautifully, But I think that, that's such a, I'm so happy about the way it ended. And I think a lot of that is down to you, the effort that you put in and the way that you've tried to welcome him. And I'm just, I'm sorry that perhaps you had a tougher time when you went through the same thing.

LC: Yeah.

OD: But I think that's made you much more empathetic about his experience and, you know, you've probably made his experience of being reunited with you so much warmer and stronger and, because of that.

LC: Yeah.

OD: I think that really comes across. Can I ask you one more question?

LC: You can.

OD: It's more of an overview question, because you've given me a lot.

LC: [Blows nose and coughs] Right okay.

OD: So it's a question about the kind of research that we do and how you would fit into it.

LC: [Coughs]

OD: And there's no real, like, right answer, and if you would rather not answer, that's fine too. But because we wanted an oral history component to this research and we wanted people to, to be able to give testimony as we speak, I think I wanted to know sort of what is it that an inquiry or further action taken by politicians, what would it mean to you and what, what would something like that mean to you? Because obviously the women who we've interviewed are people who've been at the forefront of these institutions and they have the experiences that we're sort of presenting, and I want to give you a chance to say what it is that an inquiry would mean.

LC: I never felt that I was physically abused. But I al-, I do feel that I was emotionally abused. Mentally abused. My life, all my life has been coloured by the treatment that I received. I don't really know what happened when I was a baby, but there's something very wrong somewhere. My life afterwards, from the adoption, I feel as if there was something funny with that adoption too, because they were a lot older and they shouldn't have been adopting children at that age. It's now an age limit, and there was an age limit then, so there's something wrong there too. So that coloured, there's things happened in my life

that came, stemmed from where I came from, that can't be changed. And then to end up where I did, and the scar, the emotional scar that those women placed on me, somebody needs to answer to it. And to let children be put in a place like that and treated the way they were, it's immoral and it's wrong. It'll never get me back the years, it'll never, but it'll draw a line under it, and I think the church, the nuns, they have to answer for their behaviour. Their inhuman behaviour, really, at the end of the day. I mean they took, they took our identity, they took money from the government to keep us there, with a bit of food and that was it. You washed your own washing and everything else, like they'd no outgoings except for a bit of food, and it wasn't great food either. They did that and they won't to hold their hands up to it, and I think it's time that somebody spoke out and said "you need to answer to this". And as I said to you, I have completely disowned anything to do with the Catholic Church, nuns, priests, I want nothing to do with them. I know you can't tar everybody with the same brush, but the institution is there and they allowed that to go on.

OD: Yeah.

LC: And I know much more, worse people than me, people who suffered sexual and physical abuse, and thank God I didn't. A bit of physical, because to do the work that we did in that place was ridiculous.

OD: Yeah.

LC: So that's the way I kind of feel, that if somebody, somebody has got to bring these people to book. And there's so many women and girls who are now dead, there's so many women and girls who are still living with this and can't speak out because they're afraid, because they haven't told their families, so it's

up to the few that can speak out to speak for them. So that's really, basically what I feel.

OD: Thank you so much, I think that's an excellent statement. I'm gonna pause it, if I stop...

[END OF INTERVIEW.]